



Usman's latest success in Bellator came against Alexander Shabliy. Shabliy's MMA journey began with karate, and he later added boxing and Muay Thai into his skill set at a young age. With a 5-0 record in the Bellator cage, including wins over Bobby King Primus and another former champion, Patricky Pitbull, Shabliy was a formidable contender heading into his fight with Usman at Bellator 301.

Despite the build-up, the duel lacked action and excitement, with Nurmagomedov prevailing through a tactical approach, using his punches and kicks. The score read 50-45, 49-46, 49-46 in his favour.

The 26-year-old Nurmagomedov described his Russian opponent as "such a tough guy". He added, "I am happy with my victory and want to defend my title next in Dubai."

If the champion defeats Paul Hughes in their upcoming October match, AJ McKee, a former Bellator featherweight champion, could be his next challenger.

While he may add another feather to his Bellator cap, will he eventually make his way to the UFC? Only time will tell.

Sean Brady walks the talk

In the final bout at UFC APEX, Sean Brady defeated former championship challenger Gilbert Burns via unanimous decision, marking the biggest victory of his career.

Throughout the five rounds, Burns landed a few clean shots, but Brady, based in Philadelphia, was the more active fighter. He utilised a combination of well-timed strikes and patient punches to outmanoeuvre the Brazilian veteran. For most of the fight, Brady dictated the pace, setting the terms of engagement and proving to be the more effective fighter overall. Anytime Burns gained momentum, Brady worked to close the distance and regain control.

The three judges scored the bout in favour of Brady, who has now won three consecutive fights after

No match: Sean Brady (right) utilised a combination of well-timed strikes and patient punches to outmanoeuvre Gilbert Burns in the final bout at UFC APEX. GETTY IMAGES

suffering his only career defeat to current champion Belal Muhammad in Abu Dhabi two years ago. After this victory over the battle-tested Burns, combined with his impressive performance against Kelvin Gastelum last year, Brady should be in title contention in the fiercely competitive welterweight division.

Meanwhile, the all-Brazilian flyweight clash between Natalia Silva and Jessica Andrade lived up to its billing, with Silva claiming the biggest win of her career in the co-main event.

With her unanimous decision victory, Silva moved to 6-0 inside the Octagon, extending her overall winning streak to 12 and establishing herself as a top contender.